CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

CHEF
IN THE AI ERA

The chef title is real, the pay is real — and neither is available to you in 2027. BLS requires 5+ years of kitchen experience before the seat exists.

★ **TL;DR — NO. Chefs and Head Cooks earn a verified median of $62,470 (BLS, May 2025), growth +7%, ~25,200 openings a year — but BLS typical entry requires 5 years or more of related experience. The beginner's actual job is cook: all-cooks median $36,640, restaurant cooks $17.98/hr. Culinary school does not shorten the gate: certificate graduates average ~$28,440 five years out. This roadmap is the way through — the cook years are the shared foundation for both doors below.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

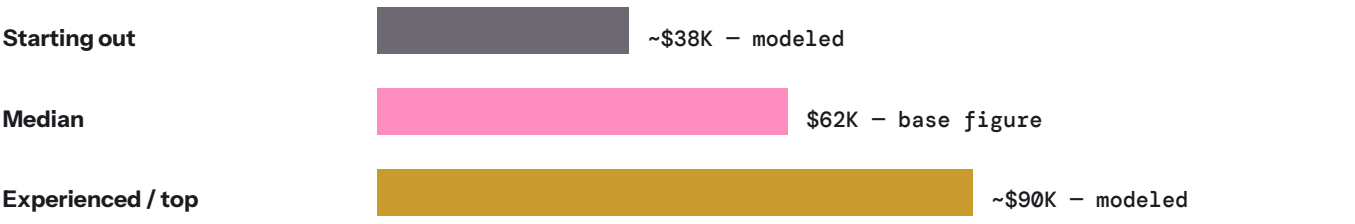
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$62K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Fails as a start because: the titled seat is experience-gated (5+ years, BLS), so a 2027 beginner is hired as a cook at ~$37K, not as a chef at $62,470.
- The pay error: the old card's $75K is +20% over the verified median — it matches only the top industry slice (traveler accommodation, $74,380), not the occupation.
- Not an AI story: kitchen robots are stuck in chain pilots (Flippy at 14 White Castle units, down from 17; Chipotle's Chippy pilot ended in 2023; the ghost-kitchen model collapsed). The chef's work — menus, tasting, training cooks — is not what is being automated.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Chef is a ~$62K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A CHEF ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Develop menus, recipes and costing for a kitchen
- ✓ Supervise, train and schedule the cooks under you
- ✓ Taste, season and approve dishes before they leave the pass
- ✓ Own sanitation, purchasing and food-cost numbers

Think: a head coach who also wrote the playbook — hired only after years playing the position at a lower level.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Fry-station and prep pilots at chain scale only: Miso Robotics' Flippy runs at 14 White Castle units; Chipotle's Chippy chip robot pilot ended in 2023; Creator's burger-robot restaurant closed its only location in 2020. All of it targets the cook layer, not the chef seat.	Menu development, recipe judgment, tasting, training cooks, and the sanitation and purchasing calls a kitchen lives or dies by — BLS's duty list for this occupation is judgment work.

⚠ **Culinary school is the expensive trap here. Programmes run up to $60,000+, and U.S. Department of Education data (via Chef's Pencil) puts certificate graduates at ~$28,440 and associate graduates at ~$33,690 five years after graduation — cook-level pay, with the 5+ years of kitchen experience still owed. The degree does not buy the seat.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The occupation itself is healthy: +7% growth, 25,200 openings a year ✓ No degree or licence ladder gates it — experience is the whole currency ✓ The cook years you serve are paid training toward two better seats	✗ Five-plus years of nights, weekends, burns and cuts before the title exists ✗ Beginner pay is ~$37K, roughly half the figure the old card sold ✗ The median after the climb is $62,470, not $75K

Good fit? You love kitchen work itself and would happily cook for years — you just want those years aimed at the right seat.

Bad fit? You wanted the title, the pay or the TV version in year one, or you planned to buy the seat with a culinary degree.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Caterer
Food Service Managers: median $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year — more than the chef median, on a shorter ladder. BLS's formal requirement is a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience, and the rungs are printed: floor ~$35K, first-line supervisor $45,370, manager $69,390. Your kitchen years count double here — a manager who can actually cook is the hire every operator wants. First move: take cook shifts in a well-run group and say out loud, early, that you want the supervisor track.	The only food title in this batch a beginner can enter two ways in year one: hired into catering work immediately at the cook layer, or legally opening a permitted catering business the same year (permit stack in the Caterer roadmap). The business anchor is the Food Service Managers median of $69,390 (+6%, ~38,800 openings/yr) — labelled as an anchor, because catering owner income has no verified median. First move: cook for a catering company through one full event season and learn the event math — food cost, staffing, rentals — from inside.

Smart move: Treat the line-cook years as a paid apprenticeship with an exit target, not an identity. Pick the employer for its ladder (restaurant group or catering company), not for the fanciest menu.

Where you land after: You land running a food operation — a restaurant as its manager, or events as a caterer — with real kitchen years underneath you instead of a certificate and a debt.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	TAKE THE	PICK YOUR	COLLECT THE	GET THE	MOVE UP

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS Chefs and Head Cooks page: $62,470 median, and the entry line — 5 years or more of related experience
- Price your actual first job: cook, ~$36,640 median (restaurant cooks $17.98/hr)

STEP 2 — Take the cook job on purpose

WEEKS 1-4

- Get hired as a cook in a restaurant group or catering company with a visible ladder
- Skip culinary school for now — the data says its graduates land at the same cook pay, with debt

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 2

- Door A if you want the salaried climb: supervisor duties, then the manager seat at $69,390
- Door B if you want your own book of business: catering events, permits, then your own operation

STEP 4 — Collect the rungs, not just hours

MONTHS 2–12

- Volunteer for the tasks the next seat owns: ordering, costing, training new cooks, closing numbers
- Keep a written record of every station and duty — that record is your promotion file

STEP 5 — Get the one flat credential

WHEN REQUIRED

- Food handler's certification where your state or locality requires it — hours, not a programme
- Food Protection Manager Certification when you approach supervisor level — a single exam

STEP 6 — Move up or out on schedule

YEAR 1–2

- If no supervisor conversation has happened by month 12, take your cook record to a group that promotes
- Revisit the chef title at year 5 — with the experience BLS actually asks for

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the BLS Chefs and Head Cooks page — median, growth, and the 5-year experience line.

□ Days 1–30: cook applications out to restaurant groups and catering companies with real ladders.

□ Days 31–60: working the line; door chosen; promotion record started.

□ Days 61–90: first above-the-line duties owned — an order placed, a new cook trained, a close done right.

□ Day 90: you're on a ladder that ends at $69K+ seats, being paid to climb it — not paying a school to watch.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan

into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ COOK FIRST. TITLES FOLLOW. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.